

"The Power in Numbers": Resident Perceptions of Unionization

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COVID-19 Pandemic and its Aftermath



Learning Environment Disturbances

Personal experiences
Social dynamics
Organizational culture



Far-Reaching Effects

High rates of burnout,
psychological stress, decreased
satisfaction with work-life-
integration¹

Increased physician turnover,
reduction in clinical work hours²

Evolving Societal Concepts of Work



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On Calling — From Privileged Professionals to Cogs of Capitalism?

Author: Lisa Rosenbaum, M.D. [Author Info & Affiliations](#)

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What Do Trainees Want? The Rise of House Staff Unions

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Being Well while Doing Well — Distinguishing Necessary from Unnecessary Discomfort in Training

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Beyond Moral Injury — Can We Reclaim Agency, Belief, and Joy in Medicine?

Author: Lisa Rosenbaum, M.D. [Author Info & Affiliations](#)

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Project Aims

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To understand the professional identity of internal medicine residents in 2026



Explore how residents conceptualize working as a trainee, especially in the context of unionization



Explore how resident conceptualization of self may influence the perception of their sense of purpose and meaning



Characterize resident perceptions about their broader attitudes towards work and continuing education

Research Methodology

Study Design

- Qualitative study of 33 categorical internal medicine residents at two academic medical centers in Chicago
 - One program's house staff unionized in 2021
 - One program's house staff unionized in 2024
- Semi-structured virtual interviews facilitated by research coordinator not affiliated with either residency program

Themes of Interest



Professional Identity



Unionization



**Learner/Employee
Duality**



Quiet Quitting



Medical Knowledge



Wellbeing

Results

Perceived Benefits of Resident Unionization

Protection
through
transition

Agency and
tangible
benefits

Sense of
community &
camaraderie

Enhanced
wellbeing

Protection Through Transition

Unions support residents during a period of professional vulnerability

"We are a very vulnerable group where we need residency in order to progress in our knowledge, our training, and our ability to become an independent physician....**unions are essential for protecting our duty hours, for protecting our wellness and giving us...a seat at the table** when we are doing the majority of the hours and the working the hospital." (PGY1)

"Knowing that **as a resident we bring a lot of profit to the hospital** and that our salaries are very small compared to how much money that the hospital actually makes off of us. And that **we're extremely valuable...a very very valuable asset**. So yea, that makes me feel more like an employee and less like a physician." (PGY3)

"The union...protects residents who are in that position where they're **in a transition between learning and becoming a full attending**."
(PGY3)

Agency and Tangible Benefits

Unions provide infrastructure for agency in achieving tangible employee benefits

*"advantages come from **work hours**, more fair wages or compensation...more **resources and compensation for the board exams** that we have to take...getting compensated for the very high prices of getting the testing done." (PGY1)*

*"And when I say compensation, **it's not just monetary**, right? It's talking about people having time off, maternity or paternity leave, being able to have lactation rooms, just being able to have daycare for your kids. All these things make showing up to work so much easier, things that employees at institutions have access to." (PGY2)*

*"The pay is definitely helpful. Other things, I think a lot of folks in residency, they have their own social barriers, like immigration status, things like that...it's important for unions to fight for those as well...**it's important that they feel protected as an employee.**" (PGY1)*

A Sense of Community and Camaraderie

Unions empower community within and across institutions and medical disciplines

*"It feels like there's some sort of **system in place where we can at least try to hold our employers accountable.** So I feel like **it's empowering.**" (PGY3)*

*"It feels like **we have a voice** that we can confront the hospital with. And then the nurses are also unionized. So it feels like camaraderie in a way." (PGY1)*

*"It really **makes me feel close to my colleagues** of all different specialties, which I think is enriching my life as an employee and a learner." (PGY2)*

*"It impacts my well-being because **it reminds me of the power in numbers.**" (PGY3)*

Enhanced Wellbeing

Unions reduce the mental load of residency

*"We are a bit happier and **feel that we're being seen.**" (PGY3)*

*"I think it impacts my well-being in terms of it makes me feel...that **somebody is watching my back** and negotiating for all of these things, **even though I might not have the bandwidth to do that, somebody is.**" (PGY3)*

*"I guess that does also enrich my life as a learner too, because I'm not worried about how I'm going to get to work because I know it's going to be paid for. And then...**all of the benefits support me and my ability to be a good doctor for my patients,** which is ultimately why it's important to me to be part of the union." (PGY2)*

*"It definitely helps to **have people who care for my life as a physician** so that **I can provide good care.**" (PGY2)*

Unionization's Impact on Resident Professional Identity

Resident as
learner

Resident as
employee

Resident as Learner

Being unionized promotes or does not effect identity as a learner

“Residents who are well are better learners...If you don’t need to be as worried about how you can put food on the table and provide for others, then I think **you have more mental energy to spend on being a better learner.**” (PGY1)

*“it manifests itself into us wanting to be or **participate more in learning on the job.**”* (PGY1)

“when money is a stressor outside of work, then it affects your learning.”
(PGY3)

*“We’re advocating for fair institutional benefits and treatment. And so I feel like **my experience as a resident is being better protected and I can focus more on learning.**”*(PGY2)

*“I can focus less on the money aspect and know that, ‘hey, **I’m getting a stable salary and I can focus more on learning,**”* (PGY3)

Resident as Employee

Being unionized promotes identity as an employee

"I'm actually an employee now because I have access to a union.'

*And I should be **thinking of myself also as an employee, not just as a continuation of medical school.**" (PGY1)*

*"it ...almost has stressed the fact that **we're employees as much as we are learners.**" (PGY2)*

*"a reminder that **we're just employees and this isn't altruistic work.**" (PGY3)*

Professional Standards

Resident Perception of Professional Standards

Residents value
professionalism
and duty to
patients

Residents value
board
certification

Perception of Professional Standards

Residents value professionalism and duty to patients

***"you have to show up and be reliable and hold yourself to a standard** to act respectfully to others...are you coming in on time? Are you doing what's being expected of you? And actually following through on it." (PGY1)*

"And there are times when you're spoken to unprofessionally...because there is this hierarchy of a mentor to a trainee or whatever. But at the same time, I feel like people forget that you're an employee.

***This is a workplace setting and we should, we all have to have professional conduct."** (PGY2)*

*"our role as a learner requires us to put in a lot of time and effort outside of just work hours...most residents probably lie that they're within the ACGME guidelines, and they're probably not. They're probably working way over that. But **it's all towards your own education benefit to be a good doctor**, but it definitely **conflicts with...** professionally and from a job standpoint, what you are legally required to do."* (PGY3)

Perception of Board Certification

Residents value board certification

*"I do think there has to be some sort of like **baseline level of competency** that you have to be able to meet...**there has to be some sort of standardization and like benchmark**, because you can kill people, obviously, very easily in this job. So I think it's not a bad thing to have rigorous exams." (PGY1)*

*"I have never been very disciplined when it comes to studying. I don't like it. It's not fun for me. But **if somebody is sick or somebody has a question, I feel beholden to find an answer** or learn about a certain pathology for them."(PGY2)*

*I mean, I think it's a standardized way of making sure that physicians that complete medical training across the United States all have the...a baseline level of understanding of medicine cause different programs have different levels of training...So **being board certified just says that you understand medicine well enough to practice anywhere.**" (PGY3)*

Key Takeaways

Bridging the Gap

Accept resident
movement to
unionize

Recognize vital
operational role
of residents

Invest in resident
education and
benefits

Beware
generational
othering

"As physicians, this is long overdue...I think it's because we go into this career giving 110% of ourselves...I can see how some people could think it's so wrong to ask for benefits that have a career that we view as a calling rather than just a job, which is personally why I think it's taken so long, but it's overdue." (PGY3)

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Thank you

